gateway for additional exploration in a field primed for deeper study and analysis in the years to come.

## A Synopsis

This book seeks to introduce readers to the interactions—past, present, and future—between India and the rest of the world. Part I: History describes India's interactions with the world in five phases, from prehistoric times to 2024. Chapter 1: Before Independence summarizes India's long tradition of statecraft captured in Vedic texts, epics, Ashoka's edicts, codes such as the *Manusmriti*, and prescriptive treatises such as the *Arthashastra* and *Nitisara*. It also tells the story of ancient India's trade and cultural links with West Asia and the Mediterranean, including the Persian and Hellenistic worlds to the West. In addition, India was deeply connected via Buddhist and Hindu religious and trade networks with Southeast Asia and China, and had varied engagements with Central Asia and Africa. The portions of the world with direct or indirect contact with India—what might be considered the 'Indianate world'—were much wider than many realize. Medieval India saw the arrival and imprint of Islamic rule in various ways. This included Mughal rivalries with the Ottomans and Safavids as well as continuing trade, commerce, and military exchanges in the Deccan. Early modern Indian international engagements involved the Marathas, Sikhs, Dogras, and Tai-Ahoms, including their military contact and conflict with modern Afghanistan, Tibet, and Myanmar. This chapter also describes the arrival of Europeans as colonists and traders, including the East India Company. Under Company rule and the British Raj, India's interactions with the world both intensified and were disrupted. This period—marked by extractive colonialism—left a lasting imprint on India's borders, diaspora, industry, governance, and politics. The Indian Army was also deployed over extended regions around the world. The chapter concludes with historical lessons for contemporary India on the importance of military power, commercial exchanges, and contested ideas.